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The ball cannoned into the billboards, and with that, a southern summer of cricket found its concluding note under the skies Down Under. Beau Webster had just essayed a lofted drive off Washington Sundar to seize the fifth and final Test at the Sydney Cricket Ground on January 5.

Pat Cummins and his men won by six wickets, and Australia had wrested back the Border-Gavaskar Trophy at 3-1 after a decade. It was a margin that years down the line may look one-sided, but for those who were present to see the action, either at the grounds or on television, this was a series that could have swung either way.

It was cricket driven by relentless fast bowling. Meanwhile, the batters were largely errant, while some offered promise and a few others regained their spark. It was a narrative that was different from the ones whipped up ahead of the contests.

When India landed in November 2024, the Australian media was drumming up hype around Virat Kohli. The package included the use of Indian vernacular languages in features praising Kohli. This was catering to a fandom, which had juxtaposed Kohli into the Sachin Tendulkar zone.

A star was needed to lure audiences to the venues and eyeballs towards live telecasts. Kohli was seen as that X factor, high on ability and even higher on marketability. But once the sporting caravan crunched past Perth, Canberra (warm-up fixture), Adelaide, Brisbane, and Melbourne, and finally paused in Sydney, a new rockstar was identified. One, who answered to the name of Jasprit Bumrah.

This series may have slipped into Australia's pocket, but if one man reigned, it had to be Bumrah. The Indian spearhead, also captain in

the first and last Tests in Perth and Sydney, respectively, left a mark so deep that it may also have revived memories of Imran Khan's 40 wickets against the visiting Indians in the 1983 series featuring six Tests. In Bumrah's case, it was 32 scalps over five Tests, and that too at a stunning average of 13.06.

It was no surprise that the Aussies' collective sigh of relief was so evident once a back-spasm-afflicted Bumrah could not bowl in the second innings in Sydney. Perhaps if he had run in and delivered those thunderbolts, India may have drawn level at 2-2 and retained a trophy that it had won during the previous two tours. "I was Bumrah'd," Usman Khawaja wryly said once the dust settled, while his mates were sipping the bubbly inside the change rooms.

If Bumrah was light and pathways, hope and magic, he also in an oblique way revealed

Future tense: In the months ahead, the selectors under Ajit Agarkar have to make some tough calls. A transition is upon the squad. AFP

